



Jaswinder describes his school days in Chennai as a “life-shaping experience” where he learned to overcome challenges, make friends, and be accepted despite language barriers and cultural differences. As a North Indian boy relocated to South India, he narrates, “I come from a Sikh family. I used to wear a turban, and the only person to do so in the entire school. So, I was always ‘visibly’ a minority at the school.”

However, he was confident enough to handle situations like being stereotyped as an aggressive North Indian. He narrates, “It was an annual day function at school. Our principal’s daughter, who was a student in the school, was performing on the stage. Suddenly, somebody from the general vicinity of where I was standing, threw something onto the stage. The principal was furious and wanted to catch the offender. Somehow my name came up. Nobody bothered to find out who the real culprit was as it was very easy for everybody to jump to the conclusion that it must be me because I was this aggressive North Indian Sardar. I kept hearing those stereotypical words.”

He tried to convince the school authority about his innocence, but no one believed him. The principal was ready to expel him from the school. He says, “Fortunately, my father believed me as we had a very open and trusting relationship. He asked me if I wanted to change that school, but I expressed my wish to continue in that school only. I intended to redeem myself. Therefore, my father convinced my principal

and I took it as a personal challenge to redeem my lost esteem. I got even more actively involved in various school activities. I tried to create visibility for myself in front of the principal. Two years later, the same principal made me the school captain.”

That experience helped Jaswinder learn something important for the rest of his life. He took the lesson to be fair with any complaint. He makes it a point to be patient, empathetic, and open-minded towards people and not carry any stereotype mindset or prejudice. Those foundational life lessons enabled him to lead and work with people from diverse backgrounds in various global and national-level projects.

While describing his school days, Jaswinder mentions his mathematics teacher, Vishwanath Sir. He was a great mentor and influencer for him. Jaswinder recalls, “I reached out to him while preparing for the IIT entrance examination. His approach to teaching mathematics was more about creating an enjoyable learning environment than doing work. This helped me to inculcate

“My father was the biggest source of strength and inspiration in my life and my mother was a great support. I was a problem child but my mother was very patient. She helped me a lot with my academics in the early days. I think, her patience and devotion helped me to focus and excel in academics. While both of my parents had great aspirations for me, my mother had higher expectations. Her expectation pushed me to excel in whatever I did.” — **Jaswinder Ahuja**



Jaswinder Ahuja with some other NCC cadets

the mindset to enjoy mathematics rather than being afraid of it.”

Becoming an electronics engineer

There is an interesting anecdote about Jaswinder opting for the electronics engineering course after completing his twelfth standard in 1982. This story reflects his passion for electronics and his dedication level. He narrates, “I was influenced by a lot of people around me who were engineers. My father is an engineer. My mama (mom’s brother) is an engineer. Two of my older cousins are engineers. Moreover, I was always interested in technology, and science was always my passion in school. So engineering was almost like a default choice. Therefore, the question was what type of engineering I would be going to do. It was the early 80s, immediately after we got exposed to colour televisions leading up to the 1982 Asian Games. Cassette players were also introduced sometime in the 1979-80

“I think the foundational lessons in my life came from my initial school days at Chennai. Being a North Indian boy from a Sikh family, I was always a minority in South India. I faced the adversity of being stereotyped but overcame the same with confidence. The foundational life lessons like the value of not stereotyping people, accepting diversity, being open-minded and empathetic, came from those experiences.” — **Jaswinder Ahuja**